been separated started trickling back. Five jawans had died of injuries in the melee. The next morning, as the head count was taken, we realized many were missing. As tense negotiations began, many of our boys, who had either got disoriented or had been briefly detained by the PLA without food or medical aid, returned to base. However, fifteen of them succumbed to the combined effects of their injuries and hypothermia.[20] It was one of the saddest days of my entire career. We are in a profession where death is always lurking around the corner. Every patrol or ambush can be your last. As a Company and Battalion Commander, my unit had suffered casualties, and I was always stoic in the face of adversity or bad news. Yet, losing twenty men in a day was hard to bear. It fell upon me to break this news to the RM. I had already spoken to him about the earlier five casualties, but we had not yet released this news. We discussed this aspect and I advised the RM that we should not try to hide the truth, which in any case would come out once we informed the families of the deceased. The media had already got a whiff of it, so it would be much more pragmatic to give out the facts and nip any speculation in the bud. In this, I was guided by what my journalist friend, Nitin Gokhale, had told me many years ago during a media capsule at the Army War College, Mhow. He had said that if you don't give the media the news, they will invent their own. Much better instead to give out the facts truthfully, and the media will only respect you for it. It then fell upon the RM to break the news to the nation, which he did with great dignity.

What about casualties on the Chinese side? Hard to say, since they have a very opaque system of reporting. Putting together the various accounts as part of the after-action debrief, of those involved in the scuffle as also those who had been detained, it was evident that they too suffered substantially.

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